power remains relevant, even if only to fund soft power initiatives. Indian policymakers will thus have to refrain from overrating the power of culture and persuasion and, instead, keep privileging the economic aspects in external engagements, including the ability to respond to its neighbouring countries' crucial developmental needs. This insufficiency is precisely one of the reasons China's Belt and Road Initiative has found such fertile ground to project both its hard and soft power in countries like Sri Lanka or Bangladesh.

Second, there are also limitations to a state-driven, formal, and proactive soft power strategy. As emphasised by S. Jaishankar, "soft power is probably most effectively projected when you do not do it in a conscious and visible manner."[75] In relation to China, this means that India may not benefit from replicating Beijing's state-driven approach to soft power, for example, through the Confucius Institutes or attempts to control foreign media coverage. In relation to India's smaller neighbours, this requires diplomatic finesse to recognise that stressing the idea of common cultural and historical roots is often counterproductive because it stimulates anxiety about excessive similarity with India. Governmental speeches and initiatives emphasising an "Indic civilization" that transcends the political borders of India are bound to embolden nationalist and religious identity politics hostile to India, whether in Nepal or Bangladesh, for example. Both in the case of China and South Asia, India's soft power strategy will therefore benefit more by enhancing non-governmental, civil society initiatives.

Third, however tactfully India may proceed, policymakers will find it difficult to institutionalise soft power and measure its actual impact. Opinion polls in the region are rare, and assessing soft power efficacy will thus depend on subjective benchmarks, which can vary from the visibility of Indian